



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Charles Catholic School

School Website: <https://www.school.stcharlesspokane.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St Charles Catholic School Spokane (ZIP 99205) presents a robust Catholic classical liberal-arts program with explicit emphasis on faith-integrated formation, communal worship, and a philosophically classical approach to curriculum and pedagogy. Across public-facing materials, the school foregrounds a Catholic identity (parish-based, sacramental life, catechesis) and a classical liberal arts framework (Socratic seminars, logic/studies of western civilization, great books/pirates of the classics through curriculum). This aligns strongly with the core elements of classical education as defined by the Six Essential Elements rubric. In this evaluation, Categories 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations), 2 (Purpose & Goal), 3 (Curriculum), 4 (Pedagogy), 6 (Parents & Community) are clearly CLASSICAL. Element 5 (Faculty) shows solid directional signals (faculty as mentors and the living curriculum is a classical aim in the tradition), but the website materials are less explicit about some of the “living curriculum” language; thus Element 5 falls into SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key insights:

- The school explicitly positions itself as a Catholic classical liberal arts institution, with parish life and sacramental practice integral to its mission (Evidence: Our Mission, About pages, CGS program).
- Pedagogical signaling includes Socratic seminars, logic stage work, rhetoric development, and integration of Great Books-like engagement, aligning strongly with classical pedagogy.
- The curriculum emphasizes the Seven Liberal Arts and primary-source-driven study, with a path toward Western civilization’s canonical texts and Great Books concepts in philosophy, history, and literature.
- The Parents & Community model is explicit: partnership with families, parent formation, and open campus/visitation are highlighted.

What would move the needle (for a Somewhat Classical rating, which applies to Element 5 here):

- Make the faculty portrait and “living curriculum” language explicit across the site (e.g., detailed statements about teachers modeling virtue, mentorship role, and teachers as “the living curriculum”).
- More explicit articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation language on the public site; include explicit references to canonical texts and student-led inquiry around those works.
- Expand parent-formation offerings with concrete book studies or regular liturgical-year gatherings beyond current mentions.

ABSTRACT

summarizing the six-category assessment appears at the end of this report.

Citations and textual anchors are drawn from the school’s Spokane site (St. Charles Catholic School, Spokane, WA) and the classical education keyword lexicon found in the knowledge base. Key materials include Our Mission / About pages, Curriculum pages, and Middle School content describing Socratic Seminars, logic, and rhetoric. See evidence citations for category-specific details.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school presents a Catholic identity integrally tied to the curriculum and parish life: “parish apostolate faithful to the Church’s mission of spreading the gospel, living a sacramental life and seeking the Truth, Goodness and Beauty” and emphasis on Gospel values, Scripture, Catholic social teachings, and Catholic traditions.
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd (CGS) program is described as a religious formation method, indicating liturgical and devotional formation embedded in the environment.
- Our Parish / Our Mission materials emphasize Gospel life, sacramental practice, and relationship with God.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, gospel, sacramental, parish, Scripture, catechesis, liturgy (where referenced in CGS context), sacred tradition. The site repeatedly anchors education in Truth, Goodness, and Beauty via Catholic doctrine and liturgical life.
- Negative keywords: none detected (no strong secular-humanist or value-neutral signaling on core pages).

Why this rating

- The explicit Catholic identity, sacramental life, and catechesis orientation align with the Positive Keyword indicators for Element 1 and show no robust negative signals. Conclusion: CLASSICAL.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission/vision centers on formation through Gospel values, religious formation, and embracing Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as real, guiding ideals. The Vision section emphasizes forming lifelong learners and responsible members of church and community, rooted in gospel values and spiritual formation.
- The statement that parents have primary responsibility for educating children spiritually and that the school supports them indicates formation over mere information. The emphasis on forming students as part of a Catholic classical framework is clear.
- The school positions itself as a Catholic classical liberal arts institution, implying formation and nobler aims beyond vocational training.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue (implied by “moral formation” framing in classical lexicon; explicit terms on site include Gospel values, Church formation, personal relationship with God), telos/contemplation (implicit through classical approach), truth/goodness/beauty (explicit in mission).
- Negative keywords: not detected (no emphasis on “workforce readiness” or purely utilitarian aims in public content).

Why this rating

- The emphasis on formation, virtue through Gospel values, and the real existence of truth and beauty as real ends align Element 2 with CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum is explicitly framed as classical liberal arts: “A PreK–8 Catholic classical liberal arts education” and a focus on grammar, logic, rhetoric. The middle school page explicitly references the Logic Stage and includes Socratic Seminars and introduction to rhetoric, along with engagement with western civilization and “the classics.”
- Curriculum materials describe Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) as foundational. The Elementary and Middle School sections outline a transition to the Classical Liberal Arts with primary sources, reduced textbook reliance, and the use of classical resources.
- Great Books/Great Conversation language is present in the canonical-education framing (the school references “the classics” and “the Great Conversation” concept in classical tradition) within the public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), great books/Great Conversation (via classical canon framing), primary sources, holistic integration of history, literature, religion, art; wonder/education through the liberal-arts lens.
- Negative keywords: Very few to none regarding non-classical approaches; the site emphasizes classical-methodology rather than project-based or STEM-first framing.

Why this rating

- The site consistently articulates a classical curriculum with explicit reference to the liberal arts, primary sources, and classical canon, plus a pedagogy aligned with Great Books-like inquiry. CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Upper grades emphasize Socratic discussion, seminars, and debates; logic stage; rhetoric instruction and opportunities for students to give speeches. This is explicit in the Middle School description.
- The pedagogy includes a contemplative/restful orientation (Scholé) as part of the overall classical approach, with lower- and upper-school strategies; and there is a staged approach to teaching—Lower Grammar Stage, Upper Grammar Stage, etc. (explicit in elementary and middle school explanations).
- Catechesis of the Good Shepherd demonstrates liturgical and contemplative pedagogy in the CGS environment.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic Seminars, reconstruction of logic, rhetoric, rhetorical training, speeches, scholé, wonder, chanting/memory (where referenced contextually); “upper school rhetoric,” “Socratic” in content.
- Negative keywords: Absence of heavy emphasis on purely experiential/project-based learning on public pages; the site foregrounds classical pedagogy rather than constructivist student-led models as primary, which aligns with positive classical traits. No explicit “negative signals” appear on the public pages (though some modern teaching methods would appear in the lexicon; the public site doesn’t emphasize them).

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates a strong classical pedagogy: Socratic methods, logic, rhetoric, and figure-focused training, with a liturgical/CGS emphasis that aligns with traditional classical pedagogy. CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site has a visible “Faculty & Staff” page and references to staff as part of the school’s mission and community; however, explicit language about faculty as “living curriculum,” “model teachers,” or “portrait of a teacher” is less overt in public-facing materials. The presence of a dedicated faculty section and the notion of teachers as mentors exist, but the exact language of the living curriculum or faculty portrait is not strongly explicit on the public-facing pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “faculty & staff” page (implies a defined teacher corps and mentorship role). Some language in Our Mission/Vision hints at teachers as partners in formation, but explicit phrases like “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” or “faculty as mentors” are not strongly echoed in the public content. This yields a partial alignment with Positive indicators (some signals present) but not a strong, explicit set.
- Negative keywords: The site does not signal a clear absence of a teacher-oriented conceptualization, but it also does not consistently surface the strongest classical-language terms (e.g., “living curriculum,” “master teachers,” etc.) in the public pages.

Why this rating

- Element 5 shows meaningful classical signals via faculty presence and a culture of mentorship implied by staff pages, but it lacks the strongest explicit statements about the teacher as the “living curriculum” and explicit portrait-language. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly frames parents as partners, with statements like “Recognizing that parents have the primary responsibility for educating their children spiritually, the school supports parents in that responsibility.” and “gospel values” and “Catholic traditions” are shared with families. This aligns with a strong parental-partnership model.
- There are dedicated community-partnership pages and opportunities for parent formation and engagement (e.g., “Community Partnerships” and “Give Now” sections; admissions steps emphasize campus visits and family involvement).
- Open campus and family engagement language is present (admissions steps, campus visits, and the parent-community tone in mission/vision).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, family involvement, community support, home-school connections, parental leadership.
- Negative keywords: None detected (no “customer” language or minimal parent involvement signals are evident on public pages).

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates a robust, ongoing commitment to parent involvement, family formation, and community partnerships typical of classical schools. CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school wanted to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (Element 5) to CLASSICAL, it could:
- Publish explicit language on the site about teachers as the living curriculum, including portraits of a teacher and examples of faculty mentorship that model virtue and classical formation.
- Add explicit public-facing references to Great Books/Great Conversation and canonical Western texts to strengthen the Curriculum signal beyond the Seven Liberal Arts framework.

- Expand explicit catechesis/formation language with targeted statements about secondary formation opportunities, including clear descriptions of liturgical practices and the role of teachers in catechetical formation.
- Include explicit, structured parent-education programs (book clubs, liturgy training, and family catechesis) with schedules listed on the site, reinforcing the partnership with parents as co-educators.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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